

Single and double consonant words

SINGLE AND DOUBLE CONSONANTS USUALLY SOUND THE SAME.

It is not always obvious if a word contains a single or a double consonant—some spellings just have to be learned. However, there are a few rules that can help.

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Consonants and short vowel sounds

In words with more than one syllable, if the first syllable is stressed and has a short vowel sound, then the following consonant is doubled. For example, the word *letter* has a double *t* because the first syllable, *let*, is stressed and has a short vowel sound. Compare this to *retire*, which does not have a double *t*. This is because the stress is on the second syllable, *tire*, which has a long vowel sound.

- The letters ***h***, ***w***, ***x***, and ***y*** are **never** doubled, even when a suffix beginning with a **vowel** is added. For example, the consonant is not doubled in the words ***washed***, ***drawer***, ***fixable***, and ***flying***.

depart

The letter *p* is not doubled because the stress is on the second syllable, *part*.

hammer

The letter *m* is doubled because the stress is on the first syllable, *ham*.

prepare

The letter *p* is not doubled because the stress is on the second syllable, *pare*.

valley

The letter *l* is doubled because the stress is on the first syllable, *val*.

Exceptions to the rule

Many words do not follow the rule above. In most cases, these are root words and are therefore not attached to a prefix or suffix. Some of these words, such as *melon*, have a single consonant after a short vowel sound. Double consonants can also occur after unstressed syllables, as in *correct*. These exceptions can make spelling difficult, so check a dictionary if uncertain.

Single consonant	Double consonant
comet	accept
domino	accumulate
epic	correct
galaxy	effect
lizard	necessary
melon	occur
palace	recommend
radish	sufficient
valid	terrific